You can return early from a function by using the `return` keyword followed by an expression. An alternative version of `countWords` with an explicit return statement follows:

```
count = (text, delimiter) ->
  return 0 unless text
  words = text.split(delimiter || /,/)
  words.length
```

Return 0 unless text is a non-empty string.

The `unless` keyword you see here isn't used all that often in CoffeeScript, but it's very handy and commonly used when returning early from a function. It's time for a quick detour about how `unless` works.

Unless

Putting `unless` after an expression has the opposite effect of putting `if` after an expression. This means that the following two expressions are equivalent:

```
eat berries if not poisonous

eat berries unless poisonous
```

If the expression after the `unless` keyword is falsy, then the expression before the `unless` keyword won't be evaluated.

Back on track now, how does the CoffeeScript function syntax compare to the equivalent JavaScript?

3.1.4. Comparison: JavaScript and CoffeeScript

The next listing presents a side-by-side comparison of JavaScript and CoffeeScript for the latest `countWords` function. Variable names have been shortened to avoid clutter in the example.

Listing 3.2. Count words comparison